coal, oil, and natural gas on so large a scale, that scientists began to worry about the increasing greenhouse effect; the dangers of global warming began slowly slipping into public consciousness.

- CFCs were invented in the 1920s and 1930s; in 1974 they were discovered to attack the protective ozone layer. Fifteen years later a worldwide ban on their production was going into effect.
- Nuclear weapons were invented in 1945. It took until 1983 before the global consequences of thermonuclear war were understood. By 1992, large numbers of warheads were being dismantled.
- The first asteroid was discovered in 1801. More or less serious proposals to move them around were floated beginning in the 1980s. Recognition of the potential dangers of asteroid deflection technology followed shortly after.
- Biological warfare has been with us for centuries, but its deadly mating with molecular biology has occurred only lately.
- We humans have already precipitated extinctions of species on a scale unprecedented since the end of the Cretaceous Period. But only in the last decade has the magnitude of these extinctions become clear, and the possibility raised that in our ignorance of the interrelations of life on Earth we may be endangering our own future.

Look at the dates on this list and consider the range of new technologies currently under development. Is it not likely that other dangers of our own making are yet to be discovered, some perhaps even more serious?

In the littered field of discredited self-congratulatory chauvinisms, there is only one that seems to hold up, one sense in which we *are* special: Due to our own actions or inactions, and the misuse of our technology, we live at an extraordinary moment, for the Earth at least—the first time that a species has become able to wipe itself out. But this is also, we may note, the first time that a species has become able to journey to the planets and the stars. The two times, brought about by the same technology, coincide—a few centuries in